FREE TRACKER · LOAD AS MEDICINE

Acceptable pain loading tracker

A simple daily log to find a dose of movement your joint recovers from, then build on it.

Why keep a log?

Two things make progress hard: doing too little to build capacity, and doing too much, which can bring on a flare. This log helps you find a dose your joint recovers from, then build on it.

Stop and contact a clinician if

- your calf hurts or swells after a joint replacement, or you get chest pain, sudden breathlessness, or new trouble controlling your bladder or bowels (call 911 or your local emergency number);
- the joint is hot, red or swollen and you feel feverish or unwell;
- a surgical wound is red, hot, leaking or opening up;
- the joint looks out of shape or cannot take weight after a fall or injury;
- the joint starts giving way, or catching and getting stuck so you can't fully bend or straighten it, or this gets worse;
- you suddenly cannot bend or straighten it as far as usual;
- pain at rest or at night does not ease when you change position, most nights for two weeks or more;
- new numbness, tingling or weakness appears in your leg;
- you lose about 10 pounds or more without trying.

These signs are worth checking before you exercise. They are not a diagnosis.

Acceptable pain guide

During activity, many clinicians treat an ache up to about 5 out of 10 as acceptable. By the next day it should be back to your usual. If it is not, do less next time. This is clinical guidance, not a tested safety limit. UNPROVEN-BRIDGE

After surgery, follow your surgeon's or physical therapist's protocol. A hot, swollen joint, or one that gets stuck so you can't fully bend or straighten it, needs a clinician, not more exercise. This does not replace advice from a clinician who knows your history.

How to use the log

1. **Write the date and the activity.** Say what you did and for how long, for example "walk, 15 minutes" or "sit-to-stands, 2 sets of 5".
2. **Rate the ache during the activity from 0 to 10.** 0 is no pain at all. 10 is the worst pain you can imagine.
3. **Check the next day.** Is the joint back to how it normally feels on an ordinary day? Circle yes or no.

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10

Adjusting your next session

- **Ache above 5 out of 10 during the activity:** next time, lower the intensity (slower, lighter) or shorten the time.
- **Not back to your usual after 24 hours:** next time, do less, for example fewer repetitions or a shorter session, until it settles. A reasonable starting point is to cut back to about half the time, distance or sets you did, then build back up over the following sessions. *This is Randy Bauer, PT's clinical guidance, not a research-tested rule.* UNPROVEN-BRIDGE
- **Hot, swollen, catching or getting stuck, or any sign in the red-flag box:** stop and contact a clinician.

Daily loading log

Date	Activity (what and how long)	Ache during activity (0 to 10)	Back to usual by the next day?
			Yes / No
			Yes / No
			Yes / No
			Yes / No
			Yes / No
			Yes / No
			Yes / No
			Yes / No
			Yes / No
			Yes / No
			Yes / No

Ache above 5, or not back to usual the next day? Do less next time. Any sign in the red-flag box: stop and contact a clinician.

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Ache above 5, or not back to usual the next day? Do less next time. Any sign in the red-flag box: stop and contact a clinician.

About the guidance in this tracker

The acceptable pain guide and the adjustment rules are clinical guidance that physical therapists use. They have not been tested as safety limits for arthritis, so they carry this grade:

- UNPROVEN-BRIDGE a reasoned link or clinical guidance not yet tested directly.

Medical disclaimer

This guide is educational. It does not provide medical advice, diagnosis or treatment, and it is not a substitute for evaluation by a qualified clinician. Talk with your physician or physical therapist before beginning a new exercise program, particularly after a recent surgery. After joint surgery, your surgeon's or physical therapist's protocol comes first. Stop any session for chest pain, dizziness, or unusual shortness of breath, and see the red-flag box at the front of this guide for signs that need a clinician.

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